THE FEAR FACTOR

The GDB survey results on public safety expose a diverse range of challenges, each demanding nuanced, state-specific solutions

Public safety is not just about crime statistics, it is about how safe people feel in their everyday lives. To capture this perception, the India Today Gross Domestic Behaviour (GDB) survey explored public attitudes on safety through six key questions—ranging from concerns about eve-teasing and safety in public transport to willingness to report violent crimes and perceptions of neighbourhood security.

Kerala leads the nation in public safety, followed closely by Himachal Pradesh and Odisha, while Uttar Pradesh occupies the bottom position—a stark reminder of the regional variations in security perceptions across India. A most telling insight comes from the experience of women in public spaces—62 per cent of the respondents claim that eve-teasing is not a major issue in their areas, but nearly 44 per cent of women report facing harassment. Tamil Nadu emerges as the best-behaved state, whereas Karnataka fares the worst, with a staggering 79 per cent of the respondents acknowledging harassment as a frequent problem.

Public transport generally feels secure to 86 per cent of Indians, with Maharashtra leading at 89 per cent and Punjab trailing at 73 per cent. Neighbourhood safety follows similar geographical variations—73 per cent of Kerala residents report no unsafe areas, while 30 per cent of Uttar Pradesh residents identify zones they feel unsafe.

Perhaps most encouragingly, 84 per cent of the respondents said they would feel safe reporting violent crimes, though historical data suggests a significant gap between intention and action. A 2017 survey found that in big cities like Delhi and Mumbai, only a tiny fraction of theft victims (7.2 per cent and 5.9 per cent, respectively) actually filed FIRs.

Traffic discipline varies dramatically across regions, with rule abiding Assam (68 per cent reporting good compliance) contrasting sharply with Karnataka (89 per cent noting violations). Meanwhile, the survey captures an unexpected regional divide over stray dogs—96 per cent of Kerala residents oppose their presence amid 316,000 dog bite cases in 2024, while 64 per cent of Uttarakhand residents express comfort with local strays. These findings illuminate not just statistics but underscore a diverse range of public safety challenges, each demanding nuanced, state-specific solutions. ■

PUBLIC SAFETY THE LEADERS AND THE LAGGARDS

RANK 2025	STATE
1	KERALA
2	HIMACHAL PRADESH
3	ODISHA
4	WEST BENGAL
5	MAHARASHTRA
6	HARYANA
7	UTTARAKHAND
8	BIHAR
9	TAMIL NADU
10	NCT OF DELHI
11	JHARKHAND
12	TELANGANA
13	GUJARAT
14	MADHYA PRADESH
15	ASSAM
16	CHHATTISGARH
17	CHANDIGARH
18	ANDHRA PRADESH
19	RAJASTHAN
20	KARNATAKA
21	PUNJAB
22	UTTAR PRADESH

While there is a broad willingness among Indians to engage with authorities and uphold safety norms, actual practices often fall short

For the detailed report, please scan the QR code

GDB: Gross Domestic Behaviour is drawn from the responses of all 9,188 participants across 21 states and one Union Territory